U.S. Scholar Final Report

Your responses can be found below.

	Response
Please enter your last name	Biddix
Please enter your e-mail	pbiddix@utk.edu
Please enter your grant year (i.e. 2009-10)	2015-16

Is this information correct?

Response
Yes

Please rate your satisfaction with the following components of your Fulbright experience:

Usefulness of pre-departure information (materials and/or orientation)	Mildly satisfied
Support from host country Fulbright staff	Very satisfied
Adequacy of stipend and other financial support	Very satisfied
Host institution's research labs	Not applicable
Host institution's library and internet resources	Very satisfied
Support from host institution	Very satisfied
Housing abroad	Mildly satisfied
Schooling for children	Very satisfied
Support from IIE/CIES staff	Satisfied

If you would like to, please tell us more:

Response

During the term of your grant, what kind of financial support, if any, did you receive from your home institution? (Please check all that apply.)

Response
Continuation of health insurance, Contributions to retirement, Leave with pay

What percentage of your salary did your home institution pay you?

Response
100%

During your Fulbright grant, did you teach course(s)?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you present lecture(s) at the undergraduate or graduate level other than as course instructor (e.g., guest lectures; special university events)?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you conduct research?

Response
Yes

Please briefly describe the nature of your research.

Response
My research project focused on how college students learn with technology. I interviewed students, conducted observations in classrooms and informal spaces, and contributed new questions to an existing survey about the role of technology in learning. I specifically studied how mobile devices allowed students to learn alone and in groups.

During your Fulbright grant, did you advise students either formally or informally?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you conduct workshop(s) or seminar(s)?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you present at any academic conferences?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you serve as a committee member at your host institution?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you implement any other type of collaboration between colleagues in your host country?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you develop new courses, curricula or pedagogies?

Response
Yes

Please provide details on the new courses, curricula or pedagogies.

Response
I learned more about the role of technology in teaching and learning and revised two of my existing courses based on what I learned.

During your Fulbright grant, did you plan and/or implement collaboration between students of your host institution and your home institution?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you plan and/or implement other collaboration between your host institution and your home institution?

Response
Yes

Please provide details on other collaboration between host institution and home institution.

Response
I launched a collaboration between the project I joined at my host institution and two additional sites. I also began work on replicating the project at my home institution, and have plans to add other sites.

During your Fulbright grant, did you speak to community groups?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you participate in cultural or social gatherings?

Response
Yes

	Response
Approximately how many people did you meet in cultural or social gatherings? (Please enter a numerical value approximating the cumulative total over the course of your grant.)	70

Please briefly describe the nature of the gatherings you attended.

Response
I attended community functions at the local library, school events with my children (aged 3, 6, and 7), board gaming groups (a hobby), a lecture at my host institution, and informal gatherings with other Fulbright recipients in the area.

During your Fulbright grant, did you write for a host country publication?

Response

No

During your Fulbright grant, did you receive other coverage of your grant in local media?

Response
No

During your Fulbright grant, did you write about your in-country experience on a blog or Web site?

Response
Yes

	Response
Please provide the URL.	http://drbiddix.strikingly.com/#fulbright-blog

	Response
Please approximate the audience reached in this capacity. (Enter a numerical value or "0" if you have no way to estimate.)	0

During your Fulbright grant, did you use social media to share your grant experience (via status updates, etc.)?

Response
Yes

Please indicate which service(s) you used. (Enter a numerical value.)

Response
449, 158

During your Fulbright grant, did you engage in other grant-related activities not yet specified in this report?

Response

No

How likely are you to do the following as a result of your Fulbright experience?

Publish your research findings	Certainly will
Publish best practices or policy recommendations related to your project	Certainly will
Develop grant proposal(s)	Certainly will
Make changes to research methods or topics	Already have
Develop new works in creative or performing arts	Not applicable
Develop new courses or curricula	Probably will
Adapt content of existing courses or curricula	Already have
Otherwise adapt your approach to teaching existing courses	Already have
Continue collaboration with individual(s) in your host country (in person, virtually or through any other means)	Certainly will
Establish collaboration between your host and home institutions	Already have
Become more involved with foreign colleagues at your home institution	Certainly will
Become more involved with foreign students at your home institution	Might
Host a colleague from your grant country or region	Probably will
Return to your host country for professional activities	Certainly will
Share knowledge related to your host country with colleagues/community	Already have
Encourage colleagues to participate in international exchange	Already have
Encourage students to participate in international exchange	Already have
Encourage colleagues to pursue a Fulbright grant	Already have
Encourage students to pursue a Fulbright grant	Already have

Please provide details about these or other tangible outcomes of your Fulbright experience that you believe are most significant. (Type or paste a response of up to 32,000 characters.)

Response
The Fulbright experience gave me the opportunity to shift my research into an area I've been interested in for some time, but unable to devote time to initiate. The literature I reviewed and the research I conducted not only enabled me to make this transition, but also allowed me to see that some of my previous notions about technology and learning were not entirely correct. For example, I'd been led to believe, empirically and anecdotally, that students expect to use their mobile devices for learning. Further, that there is a mismatch between what students want to do and what the course materials allow. I have come to see that access to technology (Wi-Fi, in particular) plays a much greater role than I previously thought and that students prefer attending lectures and reviewing material online. The students I worked with confirmed that they engage with material on their devices and connect to other learners in class and beyond, but their learning-based activities were not as prominent as I anticipated. I also was able to connect my work with researchers at the host institution, who permitted me access to their materials and gave me the opportunity to add questions to their existing survey. I am truly grateful to Dr. Vivek Venkatesh for the invitation and access to his work. He was great both to think with and to socialize with and I am confident our continued association will be beneficial. I am also indebted to his research team members, Kat and Jihan, who met all my requests with full support, helpful comments, genuine enthusiasm, and without complaint. Together, they taught me how to work effectively with a research team and I am looking forward to continuing the research with them in other contexts. When I proposed this project, I also hoped to connect my work in Canada with my colleagues in Korea. With my host's agreement, I sent the revised version of our survey to Korea and made plans to replicate the work at my institution as well as others in the US and Europe. My (lofty) long-term goal had been to study broader learner/technology use comparisons in various contexts and the Fulbright experience helped me see how to accomplish it. I have some funding possibilities and a book idea on the horizon and am considering developing a research center to serve as a clearinghouse for international research on the topic. Truly, I can see a very successful future with this research for us all that can help educators and learners thrive in digital learning environments. Working alongside students and visiting classes to observe their behaviors also helped me see ways I might restructure my current courses. I also reviewed several books on evaluation philosophies (i.e., grading) and have already introduced a new approach in two classes. Additionally, I revised how I delivered content, from a hybrid/online course to primarily face-to-face with some online content, which directly resulted from what I learned from students. The Fulbright experience gave me the space to do some deep thinking about teaching that I believe will improve my students' learning experiences.

During the course of a typical year at your home institution, how many of the following individuals do you reach in a professional capacity (through teaching, advising, collaborating, consulting, etc)? (Please enter a numerical value. If a category is not applicable to you, enter "0".)

	Response
Students:	150
Colleagues:	100
Clients:	0
Community members:	20

Aspects of local culture

Response
Quebecois is its own culture – it is one that will embrace you if you let it and appreciates efforts at trying. I have no doubt that if we lived there longer, or even moved there, we would be treated as if we'd always been citizens. It was an experience similar to the Southern US hospitality I grew up with, although perhaps even more genuine and definitely more accepting

of difference. It was a wonderful place to parent – teaching about open-mindedness, appreciating culture, understanding politics (it was an election year), and seeing that it is important and OK to stand up for something important to you (we saw lots of peaceful activism – including a school strike that had our children out for several days). Culturally, we found Montreallers to be the most accepting and generally nice people we've ever been around. We certainly stood out when we arrived – a family of five who only speak English, three of which are young and loud. Noisy didn't really seem to be a Montreal trait. But, we rarely had any trouble. The bilingualism was enlightening, as I've noted: http://drbiddix.strikingly.com/blog/bonjour-hello. We didn't need to know every phrase we heard to understand pleasant words and attitudes. The people we encountered were never upset that we could not speak French and seemed to appreciate and forgive our humble attempts to work with the language as we lived there longer. The only things we found challenging were figuring out the daycare/school system and finding a place to live. Most people we talked too were friendly during both processes, but there was no one person who could really help. The difficult part is that pre-planning did not help – we found we really needed to show up and take care of it all in person.

Recommendations related to logistics (e.g., travel, money, housing)

Response
It would be great to have someone in the host country or in the US office dedicated to helping with specific aspects of the transition. Despite the materials provided (and they were quite good), immigration paperwork, housing, and schooling were still pretty ambiguous – likely due to the individuality required for each case. Ideally, there would be someone to talk with who could advocate on our behalf or take care of some of the details. In addition, my institution needs to revise its policies on funding for grantees – it seems to be a system set up for individuals or grantees with no dependents. The reality with a family is much more expensive. We had to figure out how to live with one income, find living space for a family of five, and pay for groceries in a much more expensive city with a budget that seemed built for one person. They came through in the end, but it was a process built on an antiquated policy. I have already started conversations with at my institution so that future grantees will have an easier experience.

Web sites or other resources you found helpful

Response
Things to Do (Weekly) http://www.tourisme-montreal.org/blog/ Places to Go http://www.mtlblog.com/category/best-of-mtl/ Schools http://www.emsb.qc.ca/emsb_en/index_en.asp Immigration (although policies seem to change) http://www.cic.gc.ca/english/information/applications/work.asp Taxes https://www.irs.gov/Individuals/International-Taxpayers/Fulbright-Grants

To what extent do you think your Fulbright experience helped to...

promote international cooperation for educational and cultural advancement?	Greatly
strengthen ties between people of the United States and people of other countries?	Greatly

Overall, how would you rate your experience as a Fulbright Scholar?

Response

Excellent

Reflect on your Fulbright experience and whether you feel it has played or will play a transformative role in your life, either professionally or personally. Please explain, commenting on the elements of your experience that have made the most compelling impact on you (and/or your family). (Type or paste a response of up to 32,000 characters.)

Response
Previously, I've written about the personal benefits of experience for my family and I (link: http://drbiddix.strikingly.com/blog/our-fulbright-family-experience), but I cannot understate the professional growth I realized as a Fulbright Scholar. I was finally able to transition fully to a new research line with the support of a top scholar. I learned how to collaborate more efficiently and effectively in a research team. I (re)learned how to conduct field research in ways I had not practiced in some time and in the process, refined my own skillset. By learning from students, I was able to reconsider how I teach and spent valuable time thinking critically about my pedagogy. Overall, I believe my research, teaching, and family-life balance were immeasurably enhanced by my time in Canada. Since returning, I have been telling people who ask that the Fulbright was much more than a sabbatical, it was a blessing personally and professionally. It was a reset button I needed and a culturally enriching experience that changed my family, my work, and many of my perspectives on life.

IIE/CIES is often asked for scholar stories that illustrate how the Fulbright Scholar Program works and what participants accomplish during or as a result of their grants. Do you grant permission for IIE/CIES to provide your name when discussing your example?

Response
Yes

Are you willing to serve as a contact for information about your host country for potential or future grantees?

Response
Yes

Question Text

Response
Please contact me using the same email address where I received the link to this final report.